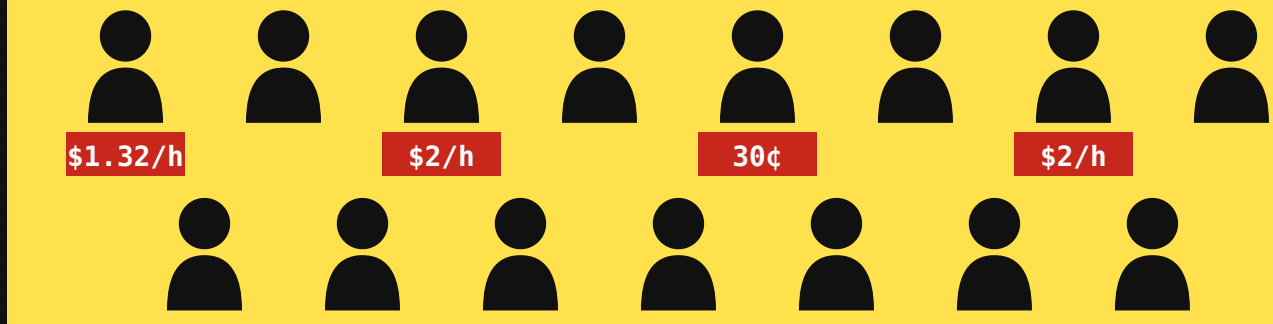
A ZINE ABOUT AI & LABOR

# WHO TAUGHT THE ROBOT?

**Behind every “smart” answer is a person who tagged, rated, sorted, or read something so you didn’t have to.**

Sure! Here you go. ✨

…BUT WHO MADE THIS ANSWER POSSIBLE?




**THE LABOR IS REAL. THE WAGES ARE TINY.**



Adeline Bohi · Nov 2026

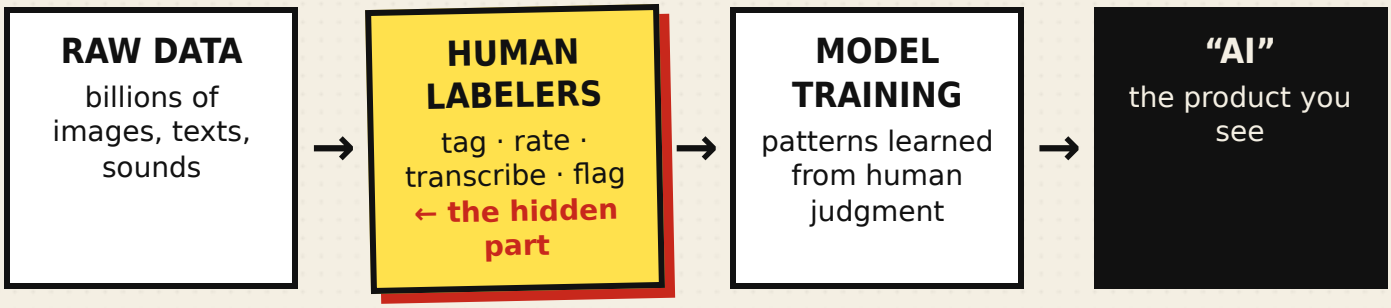
01 / THE PROBLEM

# AI DOESN’T LEARN ON ITS OWN.

**Chatbots, image generators and self-driving cars all learn from examples that humans have sorted, tagged and judged first.**

That work is called **data labeling** (or annotation): drawing boxes around pedestrians in video, transcribing audio, ranking which chatbot answer is better, flagging violent or hateful text so the model learns to avoid it.

Companies advertise the shiny end of the pipeline. The middle, where people do the actual teaching, stays out of sight.




**Ghost work.** Researchers Mary Gray and Siddharth Suri use this term for the on-demand tasks that algorithms can’t do alone, done by people the interface hides. A review of their book cites about **20 million people** worldwide in this on-demand economy, often working with no benefits and no clear labor protections.

Gray & Suri (2019); Kirkus Reviews

**The paradox of automation:** the push to remove human labor keeps generating new tasks for humans. Each new AI feature needs fresh examples, and someone has to make them.

Gray & Suri, as summarized in book reviews

02 / THE PEOPLE

# WHO DOES THE WORK?

**Mostly contractors in lower-wage economies, hired through middlemen and platforms. Rarely employees of the AI companies themselves.**

NAIROBI, KENYA · OUTSOURCING FIRM SAMA

## THE CHATGPT FILTER TEAM

In late 2021 OpenAI signed three contracts with Sama, a San Francisco firm that employs workers in Kenya, Uganda and India. **About three dozen workers** split into three teams labeled text describing sexual abuse, hate speech and violence, so a detector could keep ChatGPT from repeating it.

Perrigo, TIME (2023)

MINDANAO, PHILIPPINES · PLATFORM REMOTASKS (SCALE AI)

## THE “DIGITAL SWEATSHOP” WORKERS

Former employees told the Washington Post that **at least 10,000 people** in the Philippines did annotation on Remotasks, owned by Scale AI. Cities like Cagayan de Oro became hubs for AI data work, done from home or internet cafés.

Tan & Cabato, Washington Post (2023)

EVERYWHERE · AMAZON MECHANICAL TURK & US GIG PLATFORMS

## THE TASK-BY-TASK CROWD

Researchers tracked **2,676 workers** doing 3.8 million tasks on Mechanical Turk. In California, lawsuits against Scale AI argued that its “Taskers” were misclassified as contractors; one suit sought to represent an estimated **10,000–20,000** workers.

Hara et al. (2018); Virginia Lawyers Weekly (2025)

03 / THE CONDITIONS

# WHAT IS IT LIKE?

**$1.32–$2**

per hour take-home for Sama workers labeling for OpenAI in Kenya (TIME)

**~$2**

median hourly wage on Mechanical Turk; only **4%** earned over $7.25 (Hara et al.)

**30¢**

paid to a 23-year-old Remotasks worker for a task she spent **four hours** on. It was meant to pay $2. (Washington Post)

**1 / 10**

Oxford Fairwork score for Scale AI / Remotasks in 2023, failing on pay, safety and contracts (as reported)

**Content warning: trauma.** A Sama worker told TIME he suffered recurring visions after reading a graphic passage. His summary of the job: "That was torture." The traumatic nature of the work led Sama to cancel its OpenAI contracts in February 2022, eight months early.

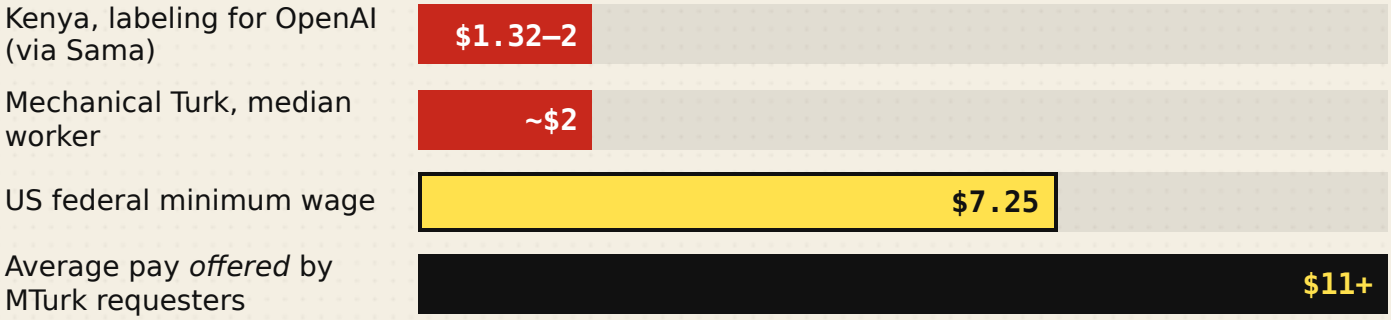
**Pay isn't just low, it's unreliable.** Washington Post reporters found payments on Remotasks were routinely delayed, cut or withheld, with few ways to appeal. Mechanical Turk researchers note that unpaid time (searching for tasks, rejected work) drags hourly pay down.

**The other side.** Sama disputed TIME's numbers, saying workers labeled about 70 passages per nine-hour shift and earned **$1.46–$3.74 per hour** after taxes. Even on Sama's own figures, that is far below US wages.

04 / THE PROFITS

# WHO GETS THE VALUE?

**Hourly pay, side by side (US dollars)**




Sources: Perrigo (TIME); Hara et al. The average requester pays more, but low-paying requesters post far more of the work.

## MEANWHILE, AT THE TOP…

**~$200K**
total value of OpenAI's three Sama contracts (OpenAI says about $150K)

**$29B**
valuation OpenAI was reportedly seeking in Jan 2023, as the story broke

**$7B → $29B+**
Scale AI's valuation in 2021 vs. after Meta's roughly $14B investment in 2025

**Read this carefully.** A contract price and a company valuation are different things, so don't treat the gap (roughly 145,000×) as a pay gap. The point is where the value ends up: a model worth billions was made safer by a few dozen people on about $2 an hour.

Sources: TIME; King & Siegel (2025); hyper.ai (2025); Wikipedia: Scale AI

05 / THE “CIS-TEM”

# INVISIBLE BY DESIGN.

**Following Hicks: systems have assumptions built in, and invisible labor is what keeps them running. Ask who built the system, and for whom.**

### 1 · THE STORY SAYS “AUTONOMOUS”

Marketing sells AI as a machine that thinks. Humans appear as a temporary fix, not as the foundation. That assumption makes their work forgettable.

### 2 · DISTANCE AND MIDDLEMEN

OpenAI does not disclose which outsourcers it uses, TIME reported. Contracts run through firms like Sama and platforms like Remotasks, so responsibility is spread thin.

### 3 · THE “CONTRACTOR” LABEL

Calling workers contractors or “Taskers” can mean no minimum wage, overtime or benefits. Multiple lawsuits in California argued Scale AI misclassified its workers; those suits were later settled.

### 4 · PIECEWORK PRICING

Pay by the task means the risk of slow work, rejected work and searching for work lands on the worker, not the company.

**Who is the system built for?** Its users and investors, mostly in wealthy countries. Who is it built *on*? Workers whose pay, safety and mental health were treated as costs to minimize. **Making that visible is a political act.**

06 / THE CALL

# WHAT CAN WE DO?

**Workers are already organizing.**

In early 2025, Kenyan data workers launched the **Data Labelers Association** to push for fair pay and mental health support; one report counted 800+ members. Its co-founder said many members keep their membership secret out of fear of retaliation from platforms. In April 2025, moderators from unions in nine countries launched the **Global Trade Union Alliance of Content Moderators** in Nairobi.

Computer Weekly; WageIndicator; UNI Global Union

1. **Pass it on.** Share this zine. People can’t demand fairness for work they don’t know exists.
2. **Ask the question.** Next time you use a chatbot, ask: *whose hands shaped this answer, and what were they paid?*
3. **Demand transparency.** Press AI companies, and schools that buy AI tools, to disclose their data-labeling vendors and pay standards.
4. **Back the organizers.** Follow and amplify worker groups like the Data Labelers Association, Turkopticon and the content moderators’ alliance.
5. **Support real employment rights.** Classification rules, minimum pay and mental health protections should follow the work, wherever it’s done.

## BEHIND EVERY SMART ANSWER, A PERSON.

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**Images & tools.** All graphics are original vector art and CSS made for this zine; no photos or third-party images are used. Research, writing support and layout code assisted by Claude (Anthropic). Laid out in HTML/CSS and exported to PDF with Google Chrome. Fonts: DejaVu Sans / Serif.

**Note on figures.** Worker pay and company valuations come from journalism and a peer-reviewed study and may have changed. Companies named dispute some claims; Sama's response appears on page 4.

# MAKE THE LABOR VISIBLE.


Adeline Bohi · DH 101 · Denison University · 2026